

Syllabus: Conditionals

PHIL-UA 200

Fall 2017

Professor Cian Dorr

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Office hour: Thursday 2-3pm.

1. Topic

This course will be devoted entirely to conditionals: paradigmatically, sentences formed using the word 'if'. As we will see, this seemingly narrow topic has turned out to be a philosophical goldmine. Theories about conditionals draw on, and shed light on, a wide variety of other topics, many going far beyond the philosophy of language: the notion of meaning; the division of labor between semantics and pragmatics; the goals of logic; the metaphysics of propositions and possible worlds; chance and determinism; context-sensitivity; vagueness; probability and degrees of belief; rationality and knowledge.

2. Format

There will be a mixture of lecture and discussion; the balance between these elements will depend on the number of people in the course. There will also, probably, be presentations; again, I want to see how many people are coming before making a plan about the number and timing of these.

3. Readings

The required text for the course is *A Philosophical Guide to Conditionals* by Jonathan Bennett. (Please buy from NYU Bookstore if possible.)

We will also be using two other survey pieces:

- the handbook article 'Conditionals', by Kai von Fintel, available online here: <http://web.mit.edu/fintel/fintel-2009-hsk-conditionals.pdf>.
- the encyclopedia article 'Indicative Conditionals', by Dorothy Edgington, available online here: <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/conditionals/>.

In addition to these, we will be reading a lot of primary literature, which will be made available through NYU Classes.

4. Assessment

The course will be assessed via problem sets and a term paper. I want to see how many people are in the class before deciding how many problem sets there will be, what proportion of the final grade they will count for, and how long the term paper should be. Participation will count for 20% of the final grade.

5. Schedule of topics and readings

1. Introduction

Bennett, ch. 1

2. Variably Strict Conditionals

David Lewis, *Counterfactuals*, chapter 1 (+ some further extracts)

Robert Stalnaker, 'A Theory of Conditionals'

Bennett, ch. 10, 12,

3. Counterfactuals, history, and laws of nature

David Lewis, 'Counterfactual Dependence and Time's Arrow'

Bennett, ch. 12 (except sect. 76), 13, 14, 19

Further reading:

Cian Dorr, 'Against Counterfactual Miracles'

? Boris Kment, 'Counterfactuals and Explanation'

4. Variably strict conditionals versus context-sensitive strict conditionals

Kai von Fintel, 'Counterfactuals in a Dynamic Context'

Sarah Moss, 'On the Pragmatics of Counterfactuals'

5. Conditional Excluded Middle

Lewis, *Counterfactuals*,

Bennett, sections 72,73, 76

Stalnaker, 'A Defence of Conditional Excluded Middle'

Williams, 'Defending Conditional Excluded Middle'

6. Indicative conditionals: material, strict, or variably strict?

H.P. Grice, 'Logic and Conversation'

Frank Jackson, 'On Assertion and Indicative Conditionals'

Bennett, ch. 2–3.

Stalnaker, 'Indicative Conditionals'

Allan Gibbard, 'Two Recent Theories of Conditionals'.

Justin Khoo, 'Indicative and Subjunctive Conditionals'

7. The Equation(s) and the triviality results

Ned Hall and Alan Hajek, 'The Hypothesis of the Conditional Construal of Conditional Probability'.

Lewis, 'Probabilities of Conditionals and Conditional Probability'

Bennett, ch. 4–6.

Further reading:

Bas van Fraassen, 'Probabilities and Conditionals'

Andrew Bacon, 'Stalnaker's Thesis in Context'

8. Expressivist approaches

Edgington, 'Indicative Conditionals'

Bennett, ch. 7–9

9. Conditionals as restrictors

Angelika Kratzer, 'Conditionals'

Daniel Rothschild, 'A Note on Conditionals and Restrictors'

Background:

David Lewis, 'Adverbs of Quantification'

Angelika Kratzer, 'What "Must" and "Can" Must and Can Mean'

10. Trivalent approaches

Daniel Rothschild, 'Capturing the Relationship between Conditional Probability with a Trivalent Semantics'

Michael McDermott, 'On the Truth Conditions of Certain "If" Sentences'

11. Dynamic and relativist approaches

Seth Yalcin, 'Epistemic Modals'

Seth Yalcin, 'A Counterexample to Modus Tollens'

12. Disjunctive antecedents and the substitutivity of logical equivalents

Kit Fine, 'Counterfactuals Without Possible Worlds'

Ivano Ciardelli, Linmin Zhang, and Lucas Champollion, 'Two Switches in the Theory of Counterfactuals: A Study of Truth-Conditionality and Minimal Change'.